

Beyond *the* Badge

An Ex-FDA Consulting Playbook

*How Former Regulators and GxP Leaders
Build Credibility, Judgment,
and Longevity in Consulting*



Sereen Morgan-Murray

Former FDA Investigator & Global GxP Consultant

Introduction

From Regulator to Trusted Advisor

Leaving a regulatory agency role or a senior quality role is not simply a career change. It is an identity shift.

For many professionals, the idea of consulting or advisory work brings both excitement and uncertainty. You know the regulations. You understand inspections. You have spent years making decisions that mattered. And yet, stepping away from institutional authority can feel unsettling. Titles fall away. Structure changes. The question becomes not whether you are capable, but how you carry that capability forward.

This book was written for professionals standing at that crossroads.

It is for those who understand regulatory frameworks but are learning how to translate that knowledge into advisory work that is credible, ethical, and effective outside the protection of an institution. The lessons in this book are not theoretical. They come from time in the field during inspections, audits, difficult conversations, and moments where judgment carries real consequences.

The transition from regulator or senior industry professional to consultant is often described as a career move. In reality, it is a shift in posture.

Inside regulatory agencies and large organizations, authority is built into the structure. Titles confer power. Systems enforce compliance. Decisions are supported by institutional backing. Outside those structures, in consulting, authority no longer comes first. Influence does. Credibility must be earned repeatedly. Judgment must be demonstrated clearly. Trust becomes the primary currency.

My own understanding of this transition did not begin with a business plan or a carefully timed exit strategy. Years earlier, while working as an FDA Bioresearch Monitoring (BIMO) Consumer Safety Officer, I participated in an inspection at a clinical investigator site in Seoul, South Korea. The Seoul experience planted a seed that would ultimately come to fruition.

A sponsor representative was present in a site support capacity. Our interactions were entirely professional and limited to what was appropriate within the inspection context. There were no side conversations, no sharing of inspection viewpoints, and no expectations beyond the formal process.

What developed instead was professional respect.

Much later, after I had left the FDA and transitioned into industry, that same individual reached out to me. At the time, the organization I was working for was restructuring its quality function. This was something I had already seen repeated across the pharmaceutical industry. He asked a simple question that stayed with me: *“Why don’t you go into consulting?”*

By this time, I had extensive knowledge of regulations, inspections, and compliance. What I did not yet understand was consulting as a profession. What followed was not a sales pitch. It was guidance. He explained how consulting actually works in practice, how independent consultants are engaged, how agencies and referrals factor in, and what early consulting opportunities realistically look like. That guidance did not replace experience, but it shortened the learning curve.

Years later, long after that inspection concluded and my badge was returned, I understood what that experience in Seoul had quietly revealed. It wasn’t about crossing lines or softening boundaries. It was about how trust, judgment, and professionalism are recognized on both sides when roles are honored and integrity is consistent.

Seoul sold me not on consulting as a business, but on the possibility of what comes after the badge: a space where experience still matters, where

credibility is earned rather than enforced, and where influence is grounded in respect rather than authority.

That moment clarified something important for me. Consulting is not an escape from responsibility. It is a different form of accountability.

Good Practice (GxP) standards form the foundation of regulated life-science activities, ensuring safety, data integrity, and product quality. Former regulators and senior GxP leaders bring deep expertise, pattern recognition, and a strong sense of public responsibility into consulting. What many are not prepared for is how differently that expertise must be applied once institutional authority is removed. The regulations do not change. The expectations remain high. But the way influence is exercised fundamentally does.

In consulting, you are no longer enforcing standards. You are advising organizations on how to meet them. Writing replaces authority. Prioritization replaces checklists. Relationships replace reporting lines. Ethics become personal, even as they remain governed by regulation, guidance, and professional discipline.

This book is not a memoir, nor is it an inspection manual. It assumes you already understand how inspections work. What it addresses is what changes after authority ends, and how to carry your judgment forward without it.

It is a practical playbook for professionals who want to operate credibly, ethically, and sustainably in advisory roles within regulated environments.

The chapters that follow explore the realities of professional transition, the mechanics of consulting practice, and the unspoken pressures that shape advisory work. You will encounter real-world judgment calls, voices from professionals who have walked this path, and honest reflections on independence, influence, and delivery.

Whether you are considering consulting, newly transitioned, or well-established in advisory work. This playbook is designed to help you move with intention, confidence, and clarity from regulator or senior leader to trusted advisor.

PART I

The Transition

Chapter 1

Why Personal Experience Matters The Value of Lived Regulatory Experience

Technical knowledge can be taught. Experience cannot.

Some professionals enter regulated environments with a strong command of statutes, guidance documents, and standard operating procedures. They can quote regulations, reference International Council for Harmonisation (ICH) guidelines and describe inspection processes with precision. And yet, what separates a competent professional from a trusted advisor is not how well the rules are known. It is how those rules have been lived in practice.

This chapter explores why time spent in inspections, compliance decision-making, and real regulatory interactions shapes judgment in ways that guidance documents alone cannot.

Why Regulations Alone Are Not Enough

Regulations describe what is required. Experience teaches how those requirements are interpreted, tested, and enforced.

Guidance documents are necessarily abstract. They cannot fully capture what happens when documentation is incomplete under time

pressure, when reasonable professionals disagree on what “adequate” oversight looks like, when systems function imperfectly within real organizations, or when people respond differently under inspection.

Professionals who have worked inside regulatory environments understand that compliance is rarely binary. Decisions are made in context, informed by precedent, pattern recognition, and risk. This understanding fundamentally changes how advice is given.

What Lived Experience Actually Teaches

Lived regulatory experience develops judgment quietly, over time. The kind of judgment is shaped by risk assessment and data integrity to balance compliance, risk, and patient protection in real time.

It teaches how inspectors assess credibility, not just completeness. It reveals how small inconsistencies often signal larger systemic issues. It shows how documentation tells a story, whether intentionally or not. And it exposes how organizations behave when regulatory pressure is real.

These lessons are not written down. They are absorbed or mentally tucked away to be retrieved at a later time and reflected on.

Professionals who have sat across the table during inspections learn to recognize when an issue is isolated versus systemic, when explanations

align with evidence, and when corrective actions are meaningful rather than performative. This is the foundation of regulatory intuition.

From Knowledge to Judgment

Judgment is the ability to prioritize, contextualize, and advise with clarity.

Lived experience teaches which issues regulators focus on first, which gaps erode trust quickly, which findings escalate concern, and which details matter versus which distract. This is why two professionals can review the same documentation and arrive at very different conclusions. One sees compliance in isolation. The other sees risk, credibility, and defensibility.

Consulting relies on the latter.

Why Former Regulators and Senior Leaders Are Sought After

Former regulators and experienced GxP leaders bring something that cannot be replicated through training alone. They bring pattern recognition across multiple organizations, familiarity with enforcement expectations, and an understanding of how decisions are scrutinized long after they are made.

Clients do not seek consultants simply to identify gaps. They seek advisors who can answer the harder questions. How will this look to an

inspector? What would raise concern first? What requires immediate attention versus planned remediation?

These questions cannot be answered by knowledge alone; they require regulatory judgment developed through lived, real- world experience.

Experience Shapes Communication

Lived experience also changes how professionals communicate.

Those with regulatory backgrounds learn to write with clarity and restraint, to avoid overstating or minimizing issues, to explain impact rather than recite requirements, and to anticipate follow-up questions before they are asked. Communication becomes purposeful rather than performative.

This skill becomes critical in consulting, where written deliverables often carry more weight than verbal explanations and may be reviewed long after the engagement ends.

Experience Cannot Be Borrowed

Organizations often attempt to replicate experience through templates, checklists, and external reviews. While these tools are useful, they cannot replace the discernment developed through lived exposure.

Experience is cumulative. It builds slowly and compounds over time. This is why credibility in consulting is inseparable from experience.

Key Takeaway

Regulations can be learned. Judgment must be lived.

Consulting begins where technical knowledge ends.

After the badge comes off, what's your next move?

For years, they carried the badge.

They enforced standards.

They evaluated systems.

They made decisions that shaped regulatory outcomes.

But what happens when the badge comes off?

This book is for FDA and government professionals who are stepping beyond public service and into consulting, industry, or independent advisory work. It is for GxP and Quality leaders, navigating reductions in force, shifting markets, and professional reinvention. And it is for seasoned experts who are not finished yet.

Leaving government does not mean
leaving impact behind.

- It means translating judgment into strategy.
- It means transforming inspection experience into advisory leadership.
- It means building credibility without the authority of a title.

This is a guide to what comes next.



Sereen Morgan-Murray

Former FDA BIMO Investigator

Founder, SMM Arete GxP Consulting Services